

Learning Intention: I can discuss how a text makes me feel and connect it to my own experiences.

Success Criteria — I can:

- Identify feelings a text evokes in me as a reader.
- Connect a character's experience to something in my own life.
- Explain why making these connections helps me understand a text.

Reading Strategy

As you read, notice how the text makes you **feel**. Ask yourself: "Has anything like this ever happened to me?" This is called making a **text-to-self connection**, and it helps you understand characters more deeply.

Read — The First Day

Jayden stood at the classroom door, his new backpack feeling heavier than it should. Everyone else already had friends, already knew where to sit, already understood the little jokes that made the whole room laugh. He didn't.

He found an empty seat near the window and sat down carefully, staring hard at his pencil case like it was the most interesting thing in the world. His stomach felt tight, the way it did before a swimming carnival.

"You can sit with us at lunch, if you want," said a voice. Jayden looked up. It was the girl from the seat beside him — Ruby, according to the name tag on her desk. She wasn't smiling in a big way, just a small, easy smile, like it wasn't a big deal.

"Okay," Jayden said, and for the first time that morning, his shoulders relaxed a little. Maybe this new school wouldn't be so bad after all.

Vocabulary Helper

Word	Meaning
Connection	A link between the text and your own life or feelings
Evoke	To bring out a feeling or memory
Relate	To understand something because it reminds you of your own experience

Parent Tip

After reading a story together, ask "Has anything like this ever happened to you?" Sharing your own related memory first can help your child feel comfortable sharing theirs too.

Try It

Think of a time you felt nervous like Jayden. Write one sentence about it:

Find It, Think About It & Apply

Q1 — Find It (Literal)

- a) What was Jayden carrying that felt heavier than it should? _____
- b) What did Ruby say to Jayden? _____
- c) How did Jayden's shoulders change after Ruby spoke to him? _____

Q2 — How Did the Text Make You Feel?

- a) How did you feel while reading about Jayden standing at the door?

- b) What words or details in the text created that feeling? _____

Q3 — Make a Connection

Fill in the table, connecting Jayden's experience to your own.

In the story	In my own life
Jayden felt nervous being somewhere new	
Ruby was kind to someone who was alone	

Q4 — Why Do Connections Help?

Circle the best reason making a personal connection to a text can help a reader.

- a) It makes the book shorter to read.
- b) It helps the reader understand and care more about what the character is feeling.
- c) It changes the ending of the story.

Watch Out!

A connection doesn't have to be exactly the same experience — it just needs to remind you of a similar feeling. You don't need to have started a new school to understand feeling nervous and alone.

Q5 — True or False?

Statement	True / False
Making personal connections can help you understand a character's feelings.	True / False
Only sad stories can create a personal connection.	True / False

Apply & Reasoning — Use what you've learned to explain your thinking.

- 1 Reasoning:** Why did the author choose to describe Jayden's backpack as feeling "heavier than it should"? What feeling does this create?

- 2 Reasoning:** Explain why sharing your own connection to a story (like a time you felt nervous) can help you understand a character better.

- 3 Create:** Write a short paragraph (3–4 sentences) describing a personal experience of your own that connects to "The First Day" — a time you felt nervous, or a time you were kind to someone new.

Quick Check — Exit Ticket

In one sentence, explain what a "text-to-self connection" is.

Answer & Teacher Support

Answer Key — Pages 1 & 2

Try It (p1): Accept any genuine sentence describing a time the student felt nervous.

Q1 (p2): a) His new backpack. b) "You can sit with us at lunch, if you want." c) They relaxed a little.

Q2 (p2): Accept any genuine emotional response (e.g. nervous, sympathetic) supported by a detail from the text (e.g. "heavier than it should", "stomach felt tight").

Q3 (p2): Accept any genuine, relevant personal connections for both rows of the table.

Q4 (p2): b) It helps the reader understand and care more about what the character is feeling.

Q5 (p2): "Connections help understand feelings" — True. "Only sad stories create connections" — False.

Answer Key — Page 3

Q1: It makes the reader physically feel Jayden's nervousness/dread, since something like heaviness is easy to imagine and relate to, even though a backpack doesn't really get heavier.

Q2: Recognising a similar feeling in your own life helps you empathise with the character and understand their emotions more deeply, rather than just reading the events.

Q3 (acceptable-answer guide): Accept any genuine, relevant 3–4 sentence personal recount connected to nervousness or kindness to someone new.

Exit ticket: A text-to-self connection is when a reader relates something in a story to their own life or experience.

Teacher Checklist

- ☐ Identifies feelings evoked by the text.
- ☐ Connects a character's experience to their own life.
- ☐ Explains why personal connections deepen understanding.
- ☐ Identifies specific language that creates feeling.
- ☐ Writes a genuine, relevant personal recount.

Teacher Tip

Some students may share sensitive personal experiences during this activity — frame sharing as optional and create a safe, non-judgemental space. This worksheet pairs naturally with "Characters, Settings and Events" (AC9E3LE01) as part of the same literature response sequence.